and its closeness to the Brazilian government, including significant Vale shareholder blocks still in the hands of Brazilian government workers' pension funds, Vale's ascendancy to its current global-player status has been characterised by a ruthlessness and singleminded devotion to high profits and generous dividends to its shareholders.

Brazilians are particularly indignant about how this national icon passed into private hands in 1997 as part of the global pattern of privatisation under structural adjustment programmes. BNDES, the Brazilian Bank for Socio-Economic Development, took on responsibility for promoting widescale privatisation of the economy. The sale of Vale is considered to be the most scandalous privatising episode in Brazilian history. The company was sold for only R$3.4 billion in a period of parity between the real and the US dollar. A submission to the Federal Regional Tribunal (TRF) in Brasilia in 2004 made explicit a series of irregularities that proved that Vale was undervalued. Some mines were ignored in the calculations, others undervalued. The forestry sector was also undervalued. Intangible assets of enormous value (technologies, patents and technical knowledge related to geology and mining engineering) were not considered. Vale's stock holdings in Açominas, CSN, Usiminas and CST were ignored. The list of irregularities is enormous. Bradesco, the bank responsible for the evaluation, took over control of Vale one year later. Vale's first president, Roger Agnelli, was an ex-executive director of Bradesco (Uchoas 2009, my translation).

Even a decade later, an informal plebiscite for the renationalisation of Vale organised by unions, students and the Landless People's Movement in 2007 was able to mobilise three million votes. While President Lula seemingly took no heed of the demands of the plebiscite, he did put public pressure on Vale during the ensuing global economic crisis. Vale tried to take advantage of the 2008 crisis as a moment for large-scale lay-offs and reneging on planned investments in the Brazilian steel industry. Lula used the popular anti-privatisation sentiment expressed through the plebiscite to justify a very public scolding of Roger Agnelli. Lula suggested strongly that for a company as close to government as Vale there was an obligation to respond to a moment of global turbulence by playing a stabilising role.

During 2009, the tensions between the Brazilian government's vision of the role Vale should be playing and Agnelli's vision of Vale's role were openly at odds. By September, the Brazilian magazine *Exame* was being quoted by other business media as the source of information on government plans to oust Agnelli. In an article entitled 'Lula criticises Vale and articulates ouster of Vale President', journalist Rafael Souza Ribeiro (2009) writes as follows: